

Utilization of E-Learning Facilities for Effective Service Delivery of Distance Education in Kwara State, Nigeria

***Tijani, Abdulganiyu Adebayo (PhD), Abdullahi, Nimota Jibola Kadir (PhD)
& Omosidi, Abdulrahman Suyuti**

Department of Educational Management, Faculty of Education, University of Ilorin.

*Corresponding Author: Tijani, A. A.

Email: tijani.aa@unilorin.edu.ng

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ABSTRACT

The study examined the influence of e-learning facilities for effective service delivery for distance education in Kwara State, Nigeria. The target population comprised all students and staff of distance education in the state. Proportional random sampling techniques was used to select the 300 respondents from the two institutions. Questionnaire was used to collect relevant information from the respondents on the utilization of e-learning facilities, while a checklist was designed to collect student's results for three connective years (2018-2020). The questionnaire was validated by three experts from and reliability co-efficient of 0.73 was obtained through Pearson product -moment correlation statistics. The four research questions raised were answered using descriptive statistics of percentages, Mean and Standard Deviation while Pearson product moment correlation statistics was used to analyze the four hypotheses generated at 0.05 level of significance. The findings of this paper among others revealed that e-learning facilities were highly utilized by the staff and moderately utilized by the students of distance education in Kwara State. Irregular power supply and fluctuation of network service impact negatively on utilization of e-learning facilities. A significant relationship between e-learning facilities utilization and effective service delivery by the staff of distance education was revealed. However, there was no significant relationship between e-learning facilities utilization and academic performance of students in Distance Education programmes in Kwara State. It was recommended that electronic facilities should be made available at cheaper cost to both staff and students and that Government and institution should improve on the power supply to enhance the utilization of e-learning facilities for effective service delivery.

Keywords: E-Learning Facilities, Utilization, Distance Education, Service Delivery, School Effectiveness

INTRODUCTION

In this age of Information and Communication Technology (ICT), there is growing concern for the use of ICT resources such as the computer, scanner, printer, Intranet, e-mail, videophone systems, teleconferencing devices, Wireless Application Protocols (WAP), radio and microwaves, television and satellite, multimedia computer and multimedia projector in curriculum implementation. In e-learning, curriculum content, the form of texts and visuals, such as pictures, posters, videos, audio/sound, multicolor images, maps, and graphics, can be simultaneously presented online to students in both immediate locations (classroom model of e-learning) and various geographical distances (Distance Education model of e-learning (Aboderin, 2011).

The e-learning is not a new phenomenon in promoting education in some parts of world. Presently, some institutions in Nigeria are using it to promote distance education (DE) and lifelong learning. E- Learning according to Sale (2002) is the use of electronic technology to deliver education and training applications, monitor learner's performance and report learner's progress. Hedge and Hayward (2004). Defined it as an innovative

approach for delivering electronically mediated, well-designed learner-centered and interactive learning environments to anyone, at any place, anytime by utilizing the internet and digital technologies in concern with instructional design principles.

E-learning gives room for effective pedagogy and curriculum implementation in the computer age. According to Offorma (2002), curriculum implementation is the planning and execution of the contents of curriculum in order to bring about certain changes in the behavior of the learners and the assessment of the extent to which the changes take place. The primary purposes of implementation are to achieve the objectives of instruction, and achieve retention and transfer of knowledge. E-learning is an instructional medium that permits alternative approaches to curriculum implementation in an ICT age. Richmond (1997), observed that there is a great link between the curriculum and ICT and that there are two major areas that technology can influence learning:

- i. Use of Curriculum- specific applications such as educational games, drills and practice, simulations, tutorials, virtual laboratory visualizations and graphics, representations of abstract concepts musical composition and expert systems.
- ii. Use of information and resources on CD-ROM, online encyclopedia, interactive maps and atlases, electronic journals and other references. Similarly, the role of ICT in curriculum implementation is recognized by the Federal Government of Nigeria in National Policy on Education (FRN, 2013) where it stated that, “the government shall provide facilities and necessary infrastructures for the promotion of ICT and e-learning”.

E-learning is usually associated with the use of computers but generally, it is a form of instructional delivery which can be provided through any appropriate electronic media such as the mobile phone, television, radio, etc. E-learning is of two major forms. One is called synchronous and the other is called asynchronous. The synchronous form is so-called because of its comprehensive features that allow for interactivity between the learning content and the learners. It has in built features like the forum chatting and audio-effect. In distance learning, students are separated from the teacher, therefore, synchronous form of e-learning aims at providing multi-outlet opportunities to meaningfully engage the learners and therefore their comprehension.

Asynchronous form of e-learning on the other hand is the direct opposite of synchronous form. Whereas, the latter by design has multifarious features, the former does not. It only presents the learning content for the students to read, internalize and download if need be. Also, synchronous e-learning allows for immediate feedback as much as possible, asynchronous may not necessarily allow for immediate feedback. E-learning in education is the wholesome integration of modern telecommunications equipment and ICT resources, particularly the internet, into the education system. (Tijani, 2017).

Distance education therefore is used as a general term to describe whatever form of education that is received without the direct presence of the teacher, but usually with the aid of one or a combination of instructional media. Distance learning refers to the teaching learning arrangement in which the learner and the teacher are separated by

physical location and time. According to Greenberg (1998), distance education is a planned teaching/learning experience that uses a wide range of technologies to influence learners' interactions and certification of learning.

The call for application of e-learning in tertiary education is to pervade and inject efficiency and effectiveness in curriculum implementation. However, in developing countries like Nigeria, e-learning is challenged with the problem of material devices such as computers, computer laboratories, internet and e-mail facilities, videophone systems and teleconferencing devices, fax and wireless applications, digital library, digital classrooms, multimedia systems and the problem of multimedia courseware development among others (Tijani 2017).

Anyira (2011) stated that the development of e-learning in Nigeria could be drew back to the introduction of electronic cable connection by colonial master in Lagos which serve as a means of transmitting information from Lagos to London office. A lot of changes have been seen in the information and communication technology industry since 1886. The provisions of telecommunication services were initially controlled by the Nigeria Telecommunication (NITEL) until 1990's when the Federal Government of Nigeria began the liberalization policy of communication industry with the introduction of different telecommunication service providers such as 9mobile, MTN, Airtel, Globacom, Etisalat to mention but few.

With this expansion, more companies were approved to provide internet services in Nigeria, and this led to improved access to the internet by Nigerians. The country has less than 11 ISPs in 2000, but by the year 2006, it has risen to above 100 and many got connected to the information super-highway. In Nigerian schools, the commonest types of e-learning adopted is tablets otherwise known as "tablet of knowledge" for secondary school students. This device serves as e-library which contains textbooks, study tips, integrated text zone with past questions and answers solution of standard examinations questions. Recent literatures emphasize that educators need to take cognizance of distance education students' competence and their capacity to act independently in using e-learning facilities. Some institutions adopted the use of intranet facilities; however, this is not well sustained because of continuous power problem and high cost of running generating set. Regardless of all these and other challenges facing e-learning in Nigeria higher education, most of the educational institutions (private and public) have stated setting up their ICT centres for internet services alone without really taking into consideration other component of e-learning centre.

The utilization of e-learning facilities has become imperative for teaching and learning in 21st century and most especially aftermath of covid-19 pandemic in Nigeria. Students no longer mandatory to obtain vital information in library in recent time as information and knowledge are now available to the users at their fingertips. Technology is therefore moving at an unprecedented rate and without proper machinery; one stands the risk of being left behind. Computer revolution and information technology have changed the world into global village in the area of communication, business and teaching. Storage and retrieval of information has perhaps opened new doors of various opportunities for teaching and learning in the school system. Technology is currently

employed for effective service delivery in Nigerian schools by students, lecturers and school administration. This has brought a wide range of solution that boosts knowledge and administrative performance. E-learning is not a new phenomenon in advanced world but it is presently used in Nigeria to improve distance education and learning.

E-learning can be seen as web-based or online learning, which is presently a fast-growing educational model in higher institutions in Nigeria. It encompasses all teaching and assessment methods that use technology such as Wikis, Blogs, Podcasts and learning management systems such as computers, internet and web connectivity to improve teaching learning knowledge and to promote research works of lecturers. This new teaching and learning method could substitute the traditional classroom teaching and learning method due to its flexibility and availability of information to a large number of students at a time. E-learning also provides easy access to any type of information essential for academic purpose through the use of internet facilities such as World Wide Web based technologies and other software. Nkanga (2007), Abdullahi and Tijani (2019) posits that e-learning is a computer based that support collaborative learning process that provide many opportunities for developing communication skills and positive attitude towards learning. Seemingly, e-learning serves as knowledge management for effective dissemination and collection of information which can positively accommodate the ever-growing need of students in higher institutions of learning in Nigeria. Though, E-learning seems to be a innovative approach to service delivery, interestingly its concept is progressively becoming eminent in Nigeria higher institutions. This is because it seems to be more flexible and more cost effective to both teachers and students due to the possibility of accessing unlimited information in all areas of learning and which necessitate the introduction of distance education that could accommodate as many learners as possible at a time.

Students at different places can access information individually and at their own pace by asynchronous learning or learn the same thing at the same time from different places (Naidu, 2006). Synchronous learning encourages working with other students in a distant class which takes place when two or more people are communicating in real time, sitting in a classroom, talking on the telephone, chatting via instant messaging in a classroom as well as teleconferencing method of teaching where students can have online learning without the teacher engaging them in the usual conventional face to face contacts (Peterson, 2009). Gunga (2010) posit that, with E-learning, both teachers and learners are eased off the stress of traveling distances and being in school for hours just to either teach or attend to lecturers. E-learning is fast ahead ground in Nigerian higher institutions but not without their normal challenges which above all includes accessibility of the e-learning facilities.

Numerous studies have been conducted on e-learning facilities in tertiary institution. Abidoye, Adelokun and Fakokunde (2014) conducted level of utilization of e-learning tools among students in Ondo State tertiary institutions. Sample of 148 students were selected from four tertiary institutions. The result shows that there is no significant difference between male and female students on the utilization of e-learning facilities. Sunday, Vera and Adenike (2018) investigated utilization of e-learning facilities in the

educational delivery system in Nigeria universities. Abdullahi and Tijani (2019) carried out digitization in education system and management of early childhood care in Nigeria. The authors reported that e-learning facilities could be most appropriate tools for effective teaching and learning. There are several areas on e-learning and distance education that are yet to be carried out by scholars. These areas include e-learning facilities utilization for effective service delivery of distance education in Kwara State, Nigeria. It is against this background that, this study examined availability and utilization of e-learning facilities for effective services delivery in National Open University and National Teacher Institute in Nigeria.

Objectives of the Study

Specifically, this study was done with the following objectives:

1. To investigate the level of utilization of e-learning facilities by staff of distance learning Education in Kwara State?
2. What is the level of utilization of e-learning facilities by student's for Distance learning education in Kwara state, Nigeria?
3. To investigate the factors that constitute to the hindrance of availability, accessibility and utilization of e-learning facilities effectiveness for distance education in Kwara State, Nigeria.
4. To examine the relationship between E-learning facilities utilization and distance education effectiveness in Kwara State.
5. To determine the relationship E-learning facilities utilization and academic staff effectiveness in Kwara State.
6. To investigate the relationship between E-learning facilities utilization and students' academic performance in Kwara State.
7. To investigate the relationship between E-learning facilities utilization and administrative effectiveness in Kwara State.

Research Questions

1. What is the level of utilization of e-learning facilities by staff of distance learning Education in Kwara State?
2. What is the level of utilization of e-learning facilities by student's for Distance learning education in Kwara state, Nigeria?
3. What factors contribute to the hindrance of accessibility and utilization of e-learning facilities effectiveness for distance education in Kwara State?
4. What is the relationship between E-learning facilities utilization and distance education effectiveness in Kwara State?
5. What is the relationship E-learning facilities utilization and academic staff effectiveness in Kwara State?
6. What is the relationship between E-learning facilities utilization and students' academic performance in Kwara State?
7. What is the relationship between E-learning facilities utilization and administrative effectiveness in Kwara State?

Hypotheses

1. There is no significant relationship between utilization of e-learning facilities and distance education effectiveness in Kwara State, Nigeria.
2. There is no significant relationship between utilization of e-learning facilities and academic staff effectiveness in Kwara State, Nigeria.
3. There is no significant relationship between utilization of e-learning facilities and students' academic performance in Kwara State.
4. There is no significant relationship between utilization of e-learning facilities and administrative effectiveness in Kwara State.

METHODOLOGY

Descriptive research design was adopted for the study. The design was considered appropriate because it enables the researcher to collect relevant data on e-learning facilities utilization and effective service delivery by staff and students of distance education in Kwara State. It also assists the researcher to investigate whether or not the facilities utilization has a significant relationship on the students' academic performance of distance education.

The population comprised all students, academic and Administrative staff of Distance education programme in Kwara State, Nigeria, while the target population consisted all staff and students of National Open University and National Teacher Institute in Kwara State. Sample of 300 respondents were purposively chosen primarily to maximize the feasibility of the study which comprised staff and students of the two institutions.

Two research instruments were employed to collect relevant data. The first one was the Questionnaire entitled "E-learning Facilities Utilization and Service Delivery Effectiveness in Distance Education Questionnaire" (EUSEDQ). The second instrument was the researcher design checklist to collect students results for the periods of 2018-2020 from the institutions. The questionnaire was validated by three experts from the Department of Educational Management; University of Ilorin. In order to determine the reliability of the instrument, test, and re-test-method was conducted on two separate respondents who were not part of the sample within two weeks interval. The data obtained were correlated using Pearson product moment correlation statistic. The co-efficient value of 0.73 was obtained which signified the reliability of the Questionnaire.

The researcher with the help of two research assistants personally administered the questionnaires to the students, academic staff and administrative staff of National Open University and National Teacher Institute in Kwara State. Effective administration of the instruments was also aided by the cooperation of colleagues and friends in the sample institutions. The four research questions raised were answered through descriptive research methods of percentages, Means and Standard Deviation. All the four hypotheses generated were also analyzed using Pearson product-moment correlation statistics. The p-values obtained were compared with 0.05 level of significance to take appropriate decision. The benchmark used for determination of the level of utilization for both staff and student is the mean score obtained; Thus a mean between 0 – 0.9 is described as

‘Low’, values between 1.0 and 1.9 as ‘Moderate’, while a mean from 2.00 and above is considered as ‘High’.

RESULTS

Research Questions 1

What is the level of utilization of e-learning facilities by staff of distance learning Education in Kwara State?

Table 1a

Utilization of E-Learning Facilities available for Distance Learning in Kwara State, Nigeria

Facilities	frequently Utilized	%	Not frequently Utilized	%
- Internet facilities	260	87	40	13
- Website	270	90	30	10
- Computer	187	62.3	113	37.7
- Scanning	219	73	81	27
- CD-ROM	215	72	85	28
Devices	200	66.3	100	33.7
-Projector	270	90	30	10
-E-Mail	300	100	0	0

Table 1a indicates the frequency of e-learning facilities utilization in the Nation Open University in Kwara State. The table thus revealed that facilities such as e-mail, website, internet, scanning and CD-room are frequently utilized with rate of 100%, 90%, 87%, 73% and 72%. While the facilities such as computer and other devices where averagely utilized with percentage rating of 63% each. On the overall, all the facilities available have above average score in the adequate rate of utilization for distance learning in Kwara state.

Table 1b

Level of Utilization of E-learning facilities by Staff of Distance Learning Education in Kwara State, Nigeria.

Level of utilization	Frequency	Percentage %	Mean
Low	18	6	0.52
Moderate	57	19	1.69
High	225	75	2.78
Total	300	100	

Table 2 revealed the percentage and means rating of level of electronics learning utilization by both academic and administrative staff for Distance education in National Open University and National Teachers Institute in Kwara State, Nigeria. 225 of the respondents representing 75% and which accounted for 2.78 mean value indicated high level utilization of e-learning facilities 57 (19%) and 18(06%) confirmed that their level of utilization is moderate and low respectively.

Research Question 2

What is the level of utilization of e-learning facilities by student's for Distance learning education in Kwara state, Nigeria?

Table 2

Level of E-Learning Utilization by the Students of Distance Education in Kwara State, Nigeria.

Level of utilization	Frequency	Percentage %	Mean
Low	30	10	1.75
Moderate	165	55	2.63
High	105	35	2.31
Total	300	100	

Table 2 showed the level of utilization of electronic learning facilities by the students of distance education in Kwara state, Nigeria. 165 of the respondents representing 55% and 2.63 mean value depicted moderate level of e-learning facilities utilization by the entire students of distance education in the state. 105 of them (35%) and 30 (10%) indicated their high and low level of utilization respectively. The reason for this finding might be stem from poor family status of the students who could not afford to purchase of computer sets while others are learning it through computer training institutes. The study also discovered that some students still show nonchalant attitude towards the knowledge and application of electronic gadgets most especially those from the National Teachers Institute.

Research Question 3

What factors constitute the hindrance to the accessibility and utilization of electronic learning facilities effectiveness of distance education in Kwara state, Nigeria?

Table 3

Factors contributed to the Hindrance to the Effectiveness of Distance Education in Kwara State, Nigeria.

Hindrances	Mean	SD	Rank
High cost of procurement	20.30	4.80	6 th
Irregular power supply	36.27	6.50	1 st
High cost of maintenance	22.75	5.87	5 th
Fluctuation of internet facilities	28.73	7.09	2 nd
Illiteracy on the part of the users	26.45	6.89	3 rd
Lack of affordable and specialized e-learning centres	24.30	6.52	4 th

Table 4 showed the major hindrances to the accessibility and utilization of e-learning facilities for effective service delivery of distance education in Kwara State. Irregular power supply and fluctuation of internet services were highly ranked. This is closely followed by the illiteracy on the part of student user and lack of affordable and specialized e-learning centres.

Hypothesis 1

There is no significant relationship between utilization of e-learning facilities and effective service delivery in Distance Education in Kwara State, Nigeria.

Table 4

Relationship between E-Learning Facilities Utilization effective service delivery in and Distance education in Kwara State, Nigeria.

Variable	N	Mean(X)	SD	P-Value	Decision
E-learning facilities Utilization	300	3.15	20.15	0.000	Rejected, $p < 0.05$
Distance learning Effectiveness	300	3.05	16.78		

Table 4 revealed that p-value of 0.000 was less than 0.05 which indicated the rejection of null-hypothesis which states that there is no significant relationship between e-learning facilities utilization and effectiveness of Distance education in Kwara State, Nigeria; Hence, there is positive and significant relationship between the two variables. This therefore, implies that availability and utilization of e-learning facilities such as internet, computer, e-mail, CD-ROM to a large extent determines the operation and effectiveness of Administrations (Management), Students and Academic Staff of Distance learning centres in Kwara State, Nigeria. None availability and accessibility of e-learning facilities could hinder the effectiveness of distance learning education. This finding agreed with Nwokolo and Anyachebelu (2012) that adequate provision of e-learning facilities could improve effectiveness of distance education.

Hypothesis 2

There is no significant relationship between utilization of e-learning facilities and Academic staff effectiveness of Distance learning centres in Kwara State, Nigeria.

Table 5

Relationship between Utilization of E-Learning Facilities and Academic Staff Effectiveness of Distance Learning in Kwara State, Nigeria.

Variable	N	Mean(X)	SD	p-value	Decision
E-learning facilities Utilization	300	3.75	23.66		
Academic staff Effectiveness	300	3.58	20.15	0.01	Rejected $p < 0.05$

Table 6 indicated the p-value of 0.01 which is less than 0.05. Therefore, the null-hypothesis which states that there is no significant relationship between e-learning facilities utilization and Academic staff effectiveness of Distance learning centre is hereby rejected. Hence, e-learning facilities availability and utilization is to a large extent determines the effectiveness of facilitators (Academic staff) of distance learning centres in both National Open Universities and National Teachers Institute in Kwara State, Nigeria.

Hypothesis 3

There is no significant relationship between utilization of e-learning facilities and student Academic performance of Distance learning education in Kwara state, Nigeria.

Table 6

Utilization of E-learning Facilities and Students' Academic Performance of Distance Learning in Kwara State, Nigeria.

Variable	N	Mean(X)	SD	p-Value	Decision
E-learning facilities utilization	300	2.97	21.52	0.051	Accepted, $p > 0.05$
Student Academic performance	300	2.85	20.63		

Table 6 indicated that the p-value of 0.05 is greater 0.05. Hence, the null-hypothesis which states that there is no significant relationship between e-learning facilities utilization and students' academic performance of distance education in Kwara state is thereby accepted. Thus, there is no much impact of e-learning facilities utilization on students' academic performance.

Hypothesis 4

There is no significant relationship between utilization of e-learning facilities and Administrative effectiveness of Distance learning education in Kwara State, Nigeria.

Table 7

Relationship between Utilization of E-Learning Facilities and Administrative effectiveness for distance Learning Education in Kwara State, Nigeria.

Variable	N	Mean(X)	SD	P-value	Decision
E-learning facilities Utilization	300	3.67	23.38	0.01	Rejected, $p < 0.05$
Administrative Effectiveness	300	3.05	21.76		

Table 7 showed that the p-value of 0.01 is less than 0.05 which thus indicated the rejection of null-hypothesis which states that there is no significant relationship between e-learning facilities utilization and Administrative effectiveness of Distance learning education in Kwara State, Nigeria. Therefore, e-learning facilities utilization is a determinant of administrative effectiveness of distance learning education in Kwara State, Nigeria.

DISCUSSION OF FINDINGS

The finding on Table1 revealed that frequency in the utilization of e-learning facilities. The result thus indicated that facilities such as e-mail, internet, scanning and CD-room are frequently utilized for distance education in Kwara State while other facilities are not frequently utilized. Result from Table 1 revealed a high level of utilization of the available facilities for service delivery by the staff of National Open University.

The interpretation of this result might be attributed to the fact that majority if the staff most especially those from the National Open University are computer literates while few ones from the National Teachers Institute are gradually learning and applying the

electronic for their job performance. This category of staff was discovered to have personal assistance that are putting them through. However, the level of utilization could be regarded as high.

Similarly, Table 2 revealed a moderate utilization of e-learning facilities by the students of distance education in Kwara State. The implication of this finding might be as a result of the fact that some students of National Teacher Institute in Kwara State are not fully computer literate on the entry into the institution. Table 3 showed that accessibility and utilization of e-learning facilities for distance education is hindered by factors such as irregular power supply, fluctuation of internet service among others for effective service delivery.

The finding in Table 4 revealed that there is a significant relationship between e-learning facilities utilization and effective service delivery for distance education. The implication of this finding is that the rate of availability, accessibility and utilization of electronic gadgets will enhance the service delivery for distance learning education in Kwara State.

The result in Table 5 indicated a significant relationship between e-learning facilities utilization and academic staff effectiveness in service delivery for distance education in Kwara State. Hence, instructors depend greatly on e-learning facilities for effective performance. The implication of this result is that facilitators of distance learning centres most especially those from the National Open University, of Nigeria, Kwara State study centre greatly utilize the e-learning facilities for effective teaching and learning. Lectures, Assignment and Examination are often conducted through e-learning facilities available to them, and hence make their job performance effective. This finding conforms to Elliot and Loebbecke (2000) that e-learning facilities enhance lecturers' job performance in acquiring the relevant skills and knowledge towards effective service delivery in distance education.

The finding as revealed in Table 6 indicated that there is no significant relationship between e-learning facilities utilization and student academic performance. Hence performance of students in examination does not depend on the rate facility utilization. The implication of this is that the knowledge and usage of e-learning facilities might not necessarily influence their examination results. This finding might be stem from the fact that rates of passes of students in examination depends on so many variables such as school climates, Teacher characteristics, seriousness on the part of the students and their ability to read and understand. Hence, e-learning facilities utilization could not determine the Students' Academic Performance.

The finding in Table 7 revealed a significant relationship between e-learning facilities utilization and effective service delivery of the administrative staff of distance education in Kwara State. This thus implies that effectiveness of the administrators depends greatly on the rate of utilization of distance learning facilities.

This finding thus revealed that Administrative of National Open Universities of Nigeria and National Teachers Institute are efficient and effective on their job performance as a result of availability, accessibility and utilization of electronic learning gadgets. Information are disseminating to the students, staff and other stakeholders within and

outside the country through e-mails, internet and other e-learning facilities. Thus, enhance their job performance.

CONCLUSIONS

From the findings of this paper, it could be concluded that academic staff, students and administrative effectiveness can be achieved through effective utilization of e-learning facilities. The electronic learning facilities such as internet, computer, e-mailing, CD-ROM Scanning and the likes were highly necessary in disseminating information in the management of distance education in Kwara State in order to enhance effective service delivery.

RECOMMENDATIONS

From the findings of the study, the following recommendations were made:

1. The management of distance education should ensure that students who are computer literate and have better application of electronic gadget are admitted to enhance and stimulate their level of facilities utilization for distance education.
2. The government and management of distance education in Kwara State should ensure a relatively stable power supply to enhance a frequent accessibility and utilization of the facilities at all time.
3. The problem of poor internet should be addressed to encourage and facilitate effective service delivery for distance education in the state.

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